KEERTHANA KUNNATH'S *NOT WHAT YOU SAW*, CURRENTLY on view at both the Saatchi Gallery in London (till September 20) and Rencontres d'Arles in France, is a striking body of work that unpacks the politics of gender, power, and representation through a lens that is at once deeply personal and socially expansive. Centring on South Indian female bodybuilders, the project confronts dominant beauty standards, interrogates patriarchal ideals, and celebrates a rarely seen expression of womanhood.

Kunnath, a visual artist working between London and India, is known for her long-form, relationship-driven practice, one informed by her experiences growing up in a conservative South Indian environment. "Photography became a way to process those emotions," she reflects. "At first, it felt like journalling, but visually. Slowly, I realised it was also a way to start conversations that others could relate to."

This impulse towards dialogue and introspection is embedded in *Not What You Saw*. The project began when Kunnath was exploring new ideas and came across a female bodybuilder on social media. "That discovery led me to a small but vibrant community.... I began reaching out to them on Instagram, and some responded. I took time—through phone and video calls—to get to know them."

The images capture not only physical strength but emotional depth. While the women are photographed in gyms and domestic spaces, Kunnath's lens is never voyeuristic. Many had previously received intrusive or fetishising requests. "The fact that I was a woman and approached them with a different perspective helped," she notes. "They didn't see themselves as superheroes, but once I explained how I viewed them...they were excited about the project."

> THE **STORIES OF THE BODYBUILDERS** ARE NOT ONLY DEFINED BY STRUGGLE. THERE ARE MOMENTS OF TRIUMPH AND RECOGNITION TOO



AS YOU SEE HER Photographer Keerthana Kunnath in a self-portrait

In South Asian cultures, the female body remains a site of scrutiny, policed by notions of modesty, tradition and 'respectability'. For these women, entering a gym or wearing competition attire was often met with suspicion or hostility, not just from society at large, but from their families. "Many were urged to choose 'respectable' professions like teaching," Kunnath recalls. "Some had relatives telling parents that bodybuilding was bringing shame to the family."

Issues of caste, class, and region further complicate their journeys. Most of Kunnath's subjects come from working- or middle-class backgrounds. One woman, when questioned about wearing a bikini on stage, replied: "Every sport has a uniform. Why should bodybuilding be treated differently?" That simple, powerful sentiment underscores the double standards these women face.

Yet their stories are not solely defined by struggle. There are moments of triumph: national titles celebrated by entire villages, newfound confidence in spaces